GEORGETOWN UNIVERSITY | McCourt School of Public Policy

POLICY BRIEF · MAY 2026

Mentors, Visits, and Learning: Evidence from Telangana's Foundational Literacy Reform

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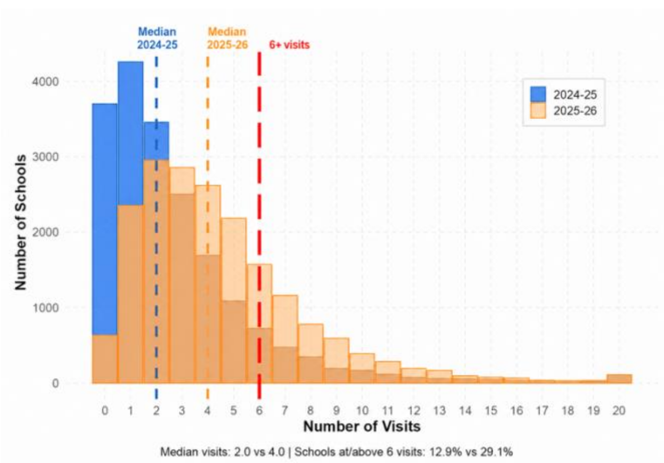
Context: Telangana's Foundational Literacy & Numeracy (FLN) mission, launched August 2022, aims to ensure foundational literacy and numeracy for all Grade 1-5 students. A central pillar of the Central Square Foundations (CSF) is the Strengthening Middle Management pathway, in which mentors conduct classroom observation visits and provide structured feedback to teachers. This feedback aims to improve teaching practices, which in turn are expected to lead to improved student learning outcomes. In addition, CSF also operates District Project Management Units (DPMUs) in which dedicated district-level teams provide structured oversight and support to schools. In non-DPMU districts, this infrastructure does not exist and support is less formalized.

SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

This brief examines whether mentor visits are associated with improvements in student learning outcomes. Using two empirical approaches: a school-level baseline-adjusted regression and a district-level difference-in-differences, we find no positive association between the number of visits schools receive and learning gains in Mathematics, English, or Telugu. The most actionable finding is distributional: mentor visits are concentrated in larger, more urban schools, while smaller, more rural, and schools with a higher share of low-caste students receive fewer visits.

Visit frequency improved substantially between the 2024/25 and 2025/26 academic years: the median number of visits per school doubled from 2 to 4 between 2024/25 and 2025/26, and the mean increased from 2.81 to 4.52. Nonetheless, this remains well below the six-visit annual benchmark for schools, even in 2025/26. The



[Figure 1: Improvement in average number of mentor visits per school between academic years 2024/25 to 2025/26]

DISTRIBUTIONAL CONCERN IN VISIT PATTERN:
Analysis shows that schools with larger enrollment and urban locations receive significantly more visits, while schools serving higher shares of Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe students receive fewer.

APPROACH 1: SCHOOL-LEVEL FINDINGS

No evidence (yet) that more visits lead to more learning

A baseline-adjusted regression relates March 2025 Anderson index scores to cumulative visit counts (Sept 2024 - Feb 2025), controlling for prior performance, school size, rural status, and SC/ST composition.

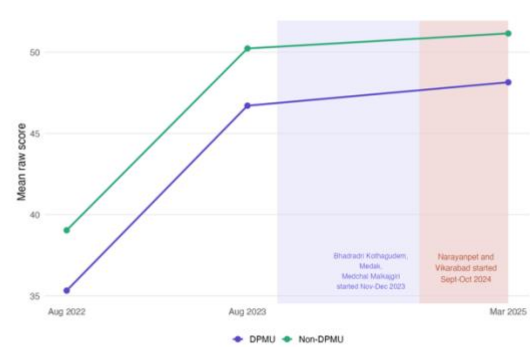
Subject	Coef.	SE	p-value
Mathematics	0.010	0.014	*0.464*
English	−0.020	0.017	*0.246*
Telugu	−0.009	0.016	*0.577*

No subject shows a statistically significant positive association between visit counts and learning outcomes. The coefficients for English and Telugu are small and negative, but not statistically significant, and likely reflect differences in the types of schools receiving more visits rather than a genuine negative effect of mentoring.

APPROACH 2: DISTRICT-LEVEL DiD

No evidence (yet) of learning gains in DPMU vs non–DPMU districts

A difference-in-differences design compares DPMU districts against non-DPMU schools (Aug 2023 vs. Mar 2025). DPMU schools scored significantly lower at baseline, but no differential improvement is detected by March 2025, for English, Math or Telugu (as shown below).



[Figure 2: No positive significant difference in learning outcomes between DPMU and non-DPMU districts in Telugu]

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CHALLENGES IN MEASURING IMPACT

Short treatment window Visits tracked over six months; outcomes measured just one month after, insufficient time for the full theory-of-change chain to operate.	**Aggregation mismatch** Visits target single classrooms; outcomes are school-level means. Assessed students may not be those taught by the teacher receiving the classroom visit and feedback.
Non-random allocation Mentors choose which schools to visit. Larger, more urban and higher caste schools systematically receive more visits, complicating causal inference even with controls.	**Quality unmeasured** Only visit frequency is used in analysis. Top-coding concerns mean recorded content may not reflect true instructional quality.

METHODOLOGY

DATA SOURCES

School census · CSF classroom observation records (2024/25 & 2025/26) · CSF student assessments across four rounds (Aug 2022, Aug 2023, Sept 2024, Mar 2025) in Mathematics, English, and Telugu.

APPROACH 1

School-level OLS with baseline-year fixed effects, round-specific baseline score interactions, and controls for enrollment, rural status, and SC/ST caste composition. SEs clustered at school level.

APPROACH 2

Difference-in-differences comparing schools in five DPMU districts against non-DPMU schools, Aug 2023 vs. Mar 2025. SEs clustered at school level.

POLICY IMPLICATIONS

1. Rebalance visits toward underserved schools

Monitoring compliance through aggregate targets obscures distributional inequities. Visit allocation should explicitly prioritize schools with higher SC/ST populations and smaller rural schools, which currently receive disproportionately fewer visits.

2. Invest in visit quality measurement

This study can only observe whether visits occur, not whether they are effective. Developing reliable quality metrics is essential for understanding what drives learning gains.

3. Allow for longer follow-up period

Two or more full academic years of linked visit and outcome data are needed for the theory of change to be properly tested.

4. Improve data links on classrooms visits and tests

Resolving the aggregation mismatch, visits target single classrooms while outcomes are school-level means, is essential to isolate directly affected students.

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